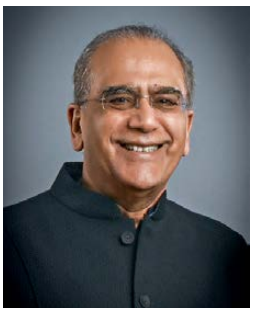
50TH ANNIVERSARY

FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



Rarely does one magazine have the privilege of a ringside seat to witness, over 50 years across two centuries, the journey of a nation. This special issue marks that occasion. We have produced 2,006 issues without a break, and I've been the editor-in-chief of the magazine for these five decades. I've had the good fortune of having a legion of India's most talented working for it. When we began on December 15, 1975, initially as a magazine for Indians living abroad, I had promised that we would endeavour to present a "total picture with its dark areas as well as light, of India as it is today, and the potentials which are being realised for what it will become tomorrow". I am proud to say that we have kept the faith through wars, terrorist attacks, natural disasters, sporting celebrations, economic liberalisation, and through all the transformations the country has undergone. We have been India's steadfast storytellers, speaking truth to power, being equal-opportunity offenders, risking the ire of generations of prime ministers. Our ever-alert band of reporters, editors and photographers have always told the story from where it happened, how it happened, why it happened, and why it mattered. Our task was to chronicle the present as it unfolded, to decide what truly mattered, and to record it with clarity and perspective, without fear or favour. This golden jubilee issue is not a celebration of nostalgia, but an exploration of a nation constantly remaking itself through upheaval and reform, conflict and creativity, despair and possibility.

We have called out facts, chronicled trends, organised primary surveys across a spectrum of fields, from attitudes around sex to appraisals of states, and written on all manner of terrorists. INDIA TODAY has pioneered in-depth stories on subjects largely ignored until then by the mass media—the environment, health and fitness, sex, relationships and, most notably, opinion polls on elections backed by the very first use of psephology in the Indian media. It was the first Indian news organisation to send its reporters all over the globe to cover important news stories, from the Tiananmen Square stand-off to the fall of the Soviet Union.

What we have done is to organise the 50 years into five decadal blocs: think of it as a gallery split into five halls, a series of flashbacks. Some of our illustrious former editors grace these pages, opening each section with an essay. As they reminisce on the decade and what it felt like to process and analyse news events for the magazine, they end up shining a torch, in ironic and illuminating ways, on the specific stage of evolution India occupied then. Following are the titles we have given to the five decades. 1975-85: The Years of Upheaval. 1985- 1995: Turbulence & Transition. 1995-2005: The Great Churn. 2005-2015: Growth and Anger. 2015-2025: Assertive India. The five decades saw 12 prime ministers, some of whom were towering personalities. Indira Gandhi, a leader of immense will and contradiction, defined the first decade. We end with the rise of the colossal Narendra Modi in 2014, when he formed the first single-party government in 25 years. In between, we tracked every other regime that came to rule India, as well as the graph of a non-incumbent: Sonia Gandhi's rise from a subject of ridicule to a powerful, cohesive force for a coalition government.

In the first two decades of INDIA TODAY's existence, the Gandhis were mainly in charge: Indira and Sanjay during the Emergency, and then Rajiv. However, post-Emergency, with the rise of the motley crew of the Janata Party, it was the best time for the magazine, as the constant bickering and shenanigans of the party's constituents yielded memorable stories. This mercurial cast of characters was too fissile to last as a group. With the half-life of an imploding bomb, prime ministers Morarji Desai and Charan Singh receded from the main stage within three years. But the period saw the magazine's popularity and credibility in the media landscape zoom to new heights.

After Indira returned in 1980, the nation was to endure more trauma. Punjab descended into violence. Operation Bluestar ruptured a sacred space, and led to her assassination. That was followed by horrific anti-Sikh violence in Delhi. The Republic was wounded, but as that shock ebbed, there emerged a tentative optimism. The mid-1980s carried the sense of a generational shift. Technology entered our everyday lives through colour televi-